

Blogging the Way Hackers Do, with Octopress

There are a plethora of popular blogging platforms available to choose from—Blogger, Wordpress and Posterous, to name a few. These have achieved considerable mainstream success, and host millions of blogs online. Lots of people adore these options, but for a hacker who finds fancy GUIs and bloated features distracting, Octopress is a good choice.

With the innumerable existing platforms, you might be tempted to consider Octopress as ‘yet another’ blogging framework. This is definitely not the case, since Octopress is fundamentally different from other frameworks in its philosophy and approach towards blogging.

Octopress is built with *Jekyll*, a static site generator. The idea behind Jekyll is very simple and elegant. It takes a template directory as an input, runs a parser on it, and generates a simple static HTML website. This provides Octopress with several advantages, but restricts it to a website with static content. However, this is not much of a restriction for blogging, as there is hardly any dynamic content associated with the task. With Octopress, there is no code and database involved, no caching and scaling issues to deal with—and, as you will discover as you explore further, with *GitHub Pages*, no hosting fee to pay as well! You get a powerful, easy to customise, easy to migrate, mobile-responsive blog. Last, but not the least, it gives you the satisfaction of looking at your blog posts as text files, and not as table attributes in a database.

Octopress allows you to blog from the comfort of your favourite text editor and shell. If the CLI is your bread and butter, the experience will be amazing. However, if you are not comfortable with the Git workflow or with working on the command line, Octopress might not be the best choice for you.

Getting started with the installation

To install Octopress, you need Git and Ruby 1.9.3 (installed using *rvm* or *RVM*) on your machine. Installing the packages is a no-brainer; you can find lots of tutorials on the Web to assist you.

The first step now is to clone the repository from GitHub. Fire up your terminal and run the following commands:

```
git clone git://github.com/imathis/octopress.git octopress
cd octopress # If using rvm, you will be asked on trust for the
.rvmrc file, simply say Yes.
ruby -v # Should say Ruby 1.9.3
```



Now you need to install the dependencies. Grab *bundler*, which helps in managing package (known as gems in Ruby) dependencies for a Ruby application.

```
gem install bundler
```

Once *bundler* is installed, you can install all dependencies for Octopress, with the following command:

```
rbenv rehash # Only if using rbenv and not RVM
bundle install
```

Moving on to installing the default Octopress theme, you need to run an included *rake* task. *Rake* is a build tool that, in the Ruby world, substitutes for the likes of *make* and *ant*.

```
rake install
```

This task copies the classic Octopress theme into the *source* and the *sass* folder of your installation. Octopress is now successfully installed.

Blog set-up and third-party configuration

The only file you need to touch for configuration is the *_config.yml* file in the root of your Octopress directory. The structure of the file is self-explanatory. Here is a partial snippet: